J.D. Miller
Travel to Korea
30 June – 7 July 2012

Saturday, 30 June 2012: Airport security clearance was preapproved. Evidently frequent flyers have about an 80% chance to get this preferential treatment. I made it to LA, upgraded to 1st class, and am now waiting in the business class lounge for departure.

Sunday/Monday, 1 – 2 July 2012: Arrived in Korea last night, Sunday night, traveling 3 hours from Seoul to Daejeon by bus. I was met at the Seoul airport by Doyun Shin, my host for this trip. I'm staying the 1st few nights at the KIGAM Guest House. The climate is humid and warm, lots of vegetation, rolling hills, small mountains. This is the rainy season so I expect we will have rain before I leave. First lectures are this morning in a few hours.

The first 2 lectures have been completed. We've had Korean food for breakfast (at KIGAM) and for lunch (restaurant downtown in Daejeon). Now I am getting ready for dinner tonight.

Tuesday, 3 July 2012: I should have told you the flight from LAX on Korean Air 18, KE 18, was very comfortable, although I did not sleep well. The service was excellent. I watched the DaVinci Code and one other classic movie. Although the departure was delayed from LAX, we arrived on time.

On Monday, in addition to the lectures, I met former students of Professor Rocky Sohn who attended my lectures including Byung-su Kim, Taegong Ryu, and Kang-In Rhee. Also I met others including Jae-chun Lee who was at UC Berkeley, and Jinki Jeong. All are researchers at KIGAM. For dinner we went to an Italian restaurant called Chiao. Fortunately I got some sleep last night.

Today I have lectures in the afternoon. We will leave for a lab tour soon, followed by lunch, and then the seminars.

We had dinner with Doyun and Rajesh Kumar at TGI Fridays, can you believe that? These new friends, Hindu and Buddhist, want another visit during which I bring my wife along.

Tomorrow, Wednesday the 4th, we leave for Ulsan at 8 a.m. to visit the smelter and recycle plant of LS-Nikko.



Dr. Rajesh Kumar and JDM,
KIGAM, Daejeon, Korea



JDM and Doyun Shin, TGI Fridays,
Daejeon, Korea



L to R - Dr. Kang-In Rhee and Dr. Byung-su Kim, KIGAM, Daejeon, Korea

Wednesday, 4 July 2012: Doyun Shin and I had a successful trip through Korea traveling from KIGAM in Daejeon by train (high speed), bus, taxi and private auto to Uslan. The main purpose was to visit LS-Nikko Copper in Ulsan on the east coast of Korea.

After arrival, we were collected at the train station by a driver for LS-Nikko Copper and taken to plant operations in the Vice President's luxurious car. LS-Nikko Copper operates a large copper smelter and refinery near Uslan. Nag-Joon Choi (U of U PhD, 1996) is Vice President, Jong-Shin Chang (one year visitor with Professor Sohn) is Manager of Research, and Sung-Sil Park (MS with Professor Sohn, 2008) is Chief of Smelter # 1. It was just like an alumni meeting. They took good care of us and after a plant tour, presentation of gifts, and lunch at a Korean barbeque we went on to the coast to visit the ocean where we met Doyun's friend, Francisca.



L to R - Unidentified, Nag-Joon Choi, JDM, and Doyun Shin, LS-Nikko Copper, Ulsan, Korea



JDM, L to R back row – Unidentified, Sung-Sil Park, and Nag-Joon Choi, LS-Nikko Copper, Ulsan, Korea



L to R - Doyun Shin, JDM, Nag-Joon Choi, Unidentified, LS-Nikko Copper,

After some hours at the beach/coast, Francisca returned us to the train station in Uslan where we got the train to Seoul. I am now in the Savoy Hotel in Seoul for Wednesday, Thursday, and Friday nights with tours of the city planned for Thursday (today) and of the DMZ for Friday.

Thursday, 5 July 2012: Sleep is still difficult. I had breakfast this morning at the Savoy before departure for a tour of Seoul. The 1st stop was the Buddhist temple. Numerous people were at the temple in prayer and meditation. Also, some seemed to have a set ritual almost like they were doing exercise.

It's a rainy day in Seoul, but other than that the temperature is very comfortable.

After the temple visit we went on to Gyeongbokgung Palace, similar to what we saw in Beijing at the Summer Palace. We arrived in time to see the changing of the Guard, about 30 dressed in robes of various colors, shell horns blue, red, green, and purple. The Guards were bearded and some played instruments, mostly percussion, but also horns, cymbals, etc. Hats were worn, some with feathers, some with flags, and some of the guards were equipped with swords. The drums were the big thing though. The Palace, buildings for the King, Queen, and Concubines were built in 1395. The palace was destroyed in the Korean War. The palace included the National Folk Museum which featured the history and social evolution of the Korean civilization.

The morning concluded with a visit to Seoul Amethyst for the purchase of amethyst jewelry and then a Korean lunch at a local restaurant. Great Grandmother (Virginia K. Rossman) would have enjoyed all the amethyst.

After lunch we journeyed about one hour south of Seoul to visit the Korean Folk Village. The tour showed many of the techniques and customs used in a typical village in the Joseon period. The village occupies 243 acres. It was interesting with some musical performances (percussion again), horses, silk production, and other handicrafts.

The tour concluded with a stop at the government ginseng store and a discussion of the high quality that is maintained for the Korean ginseng. I was surprised that they dropped me some distance from the Savoy rather than returning me to the hotel. Furthermore they gave rather poor instructions and I got lost finding my way back to the Savoy. Nevertheless I made it back in the rain after some struggle. Of course if Patricia had been with me I'm sure we would have had no trouble.

Tonight, dinner will be with Doyun Shin.

Friday, 6 July 2012: I had a good sleep last night and have enjoyed messages from Granny. It's raining again in Seoul today but after breakfast at the Savoy I joined the tour to the Demilitarized Zone, DMZ, about one hour north of Seoul. On the way, the guide told our group (about 30 people from around the world) as we passed the palace, that the kingdom for the Chosun (Josun) dynasty lasted 600 years dating from 1395. The last king died in 1920. From 1910 to 1945 Korea was occupied and controlled by Japan. From 1945 after WW II, Korea has been divided. In 1950 the Korean War began and lasted for 3 years. A cease fire agreement was signed in July 1953. Today Seoul has about 10M people of a total population for South Korea of about 50M.

In 1953 the DMZ was created, approximately 4 km wide on average and about 250 km in length stretching across the Korean Peninsula. The North Korean side can be viewed with binoculars and a bronze statue of Kim Il Seong viewed, one of 35,000 statues in North Korea. The Han River and the Imjingak River run through the middle of the DMZ. The highlight of the trip was to visit one of the invasion tunnels, 73 meters underground. Four tunnels have been discovered, tunnels that the North Koreans were going to use to invade South Korea. The 3rd tunnel, 1635 meters in length, 2 meters in height and 2 meters in width was visited and gave me some much needed exercise. The whole DMZ area is loaded with land mines, perhaps a million mines left over from the Korean War. Yesterday the DMZ tour was cancelled because there had been a security violation. A man had crossed the DMZ without authorization to do so.

The return trip to Seoul included a stop at another amethyst jewelry factory. I got back to the Savoy by about 3 pm, meeting Doyun and going out for some food at Kraze Burger. I was transferred to a suite at the Savoy for my last night in Seoul, very luxurious. I hope to sleep well tonight. Tomorrow I'm off to return to SLC.

Saturday, 7 July 2012: The storm has passed and Seoul is sunny this morning. We will leave for the Incheon International Airport in a few hours, traveling by train, with Doyun accompanying me. The Korean Air flight is again an Airbus 380. It seems that I have been upgraded to 1st class on the flight from LAX to SLC which is a blessing since I will undoubtedly be tired after the international flight from Seoul. I'm scheduled to arrive at 3:51 pm this afternoon. I expect Granny will collect me at the airport. Of course I will try to call when I get to LA.